Classification of Archived Research Projects

by Economic Activity (ISIC Rev. 5)

Seeding QDArchive · Part 2 — Data Classification

July 2026

Introduction

This report describes the distribution of economic-activity classes assigned to the research projects gathered for the QDArchive seeding effort. Two public sources were harvested: the Harvard/Murray dataverse (repository 18) and the IHSN catalogue (repository 9). Every project was placed into a single primary class drawn from the United Nations International Standard Industrial Classification of All Economic Activities, Revision 5 (ISIC Rev. 5), at the two-digit division level.

In total 1,174 projects across the two repositories carry a primary class. Classes were assigned automatically from the text extracted from each project's documents, a project's primary class being the division that best characterises its contents. The sections that follow treat each repository in turn — a histogram of the full class distribution, a table of the twenty most frequent classes, and a short discussion of the patterns that emerge — and a brief comparison closes the report.

1. Harvard/Murray Dataverse

Harvard/Murray Dataverse is the larger and more varied of the two collections. Its 602 projects — 35 as QDA_PROJECT and 567 as QD_PROJECT — are spread across 32 of the roughly 88 ISIC Rev. 5 divisions, a breadth that reflects the eclectic character of a university research archive.

As Figure 1 shows, the distribution is led by scientific research and development (136 projects), human health activities (132) and education (100); together the three account for 61% of the collection. A few applied divisions follow, and the remainder each contribute only a handful of projects, producing the long, thin tail on the right of the chart.

This is the profile one would expect of a general-purpose academic repository: the material is dominated by the products of empirical research — much of it in the health and social sciences — rather than by any single applied sector. Table 1 lists the twenty most common classes in full.

Figure 1. Primary ISIC Rev. 5 class distribution — Harvard/Murray Dataverse (602 projects, 32 classes)

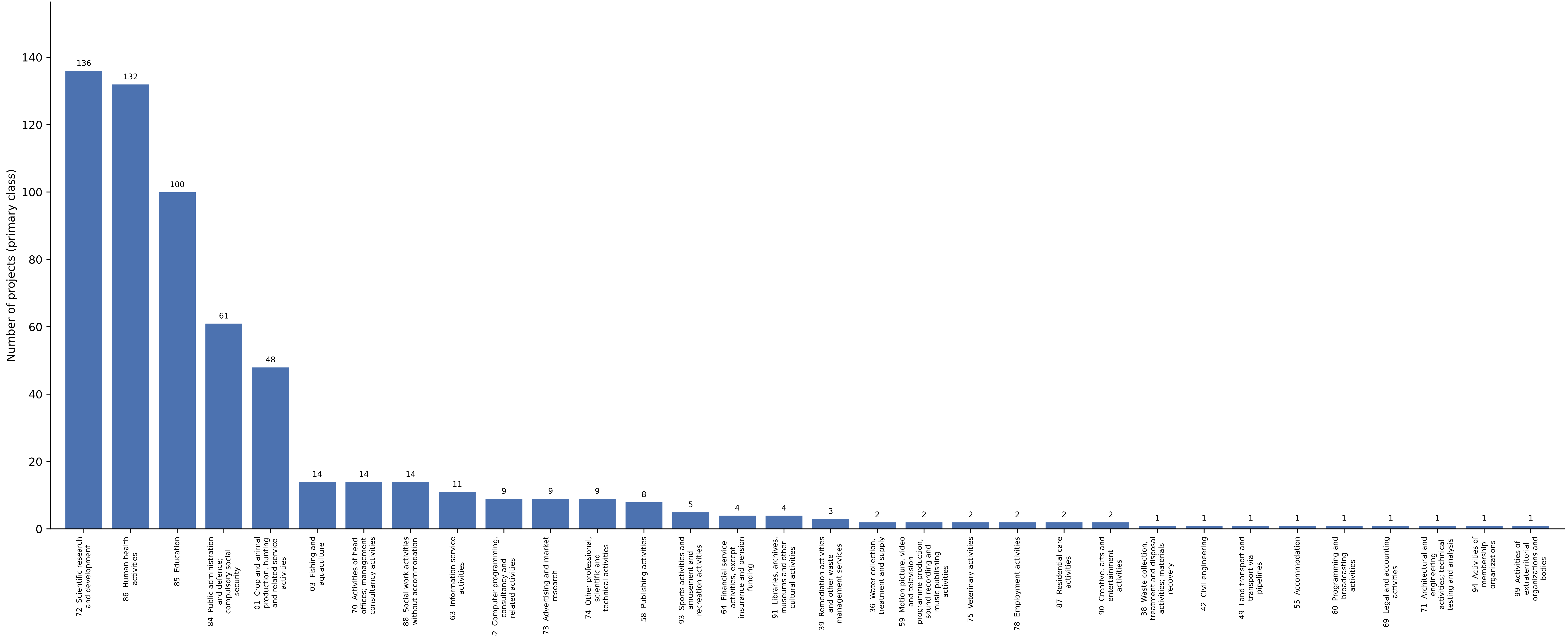

Table 1. Twenty most common primary classes — Harvard/Murray Dataverse (of 32 classes across 602 projects)

Rank	ISIC	ISIC Rev. 5 division	Count	Share
1	72	Scientific research and development	136	22.6%
2	86	Human health activities	132	21.9%
3	85	Education	100	16.6%
4	84	Public administration and defence; compulsory social security	61	10.1%
5	01	Crop and animal production, hunting and related service activities	48	8.0%
6	03	Fishing and aquaculture	14	2.3%
7	70	Activities of head offices; management consultancy activities	14	2.3%
8	88	Social work activities without accommodation	14	2.3%
9	63	Information service activities	11	1.8%
10	62	Computer programming, consultancy and related activities	9	1.5%
11	73	Advertising and market research	9	1.5%
12	74	Other professional, scientific and technical activities	9	1.5%
13	58	Publishing activities	8	1.3%
14	93	Sports activities and amusement and recreation activities	5	0.8%
15	64	Financial service activities, except insurance and pension funding	4	0.7%
16	91	Libraries, archives, museums and other cultural activities	4	0.7%
17	39	Remediation activities and other waste management services	3	0.5%
18	36	Water collection, treatment and supply	2	0.3%
19	59	Motion picture, video and television programme production, sound recording and music publishing activities	2	0.3%
20	75	Veterinary activities	2	0.3%

2. IHSN Catalogue

IHSN Catalogue presents a very different picture. Once the entries that could not be classified are set aside, 572 projects carry a primary class (572 as QD_PROJECT, 4 as OTHER_PROJECT and 22 as NOT_A_PROJECT), yet they occupy just 19 divisions and are heavily concentrated.

Figure 2 makes the imbalance plain: 60% of the classified projects fall into a single division, public administration and defence (341 projects), with crop and animal production a distant second (121). The catalogue is, after all, a register of official statistics — national censuses and large household and agricultural surveys — and such instruments read naturally as products of public administration or of the sector they measure.

Two caveats temper these numbers. Only projects found to hold qualitative primary data are classified here, so the distribution describes that subset rather than the catalogue as a whole; and because the class was assigned automatically from the opening pages of each project's documents — pages typically dominated by the sponsoring agency and the mechanics of the survey the share attributed to public administration is very likely overstated. The full ranking appears in Table 2.

Figure 2. Primary ISIC Rev. 5 class distribution — IHSN Catalogue (572 projects, 19 classes)

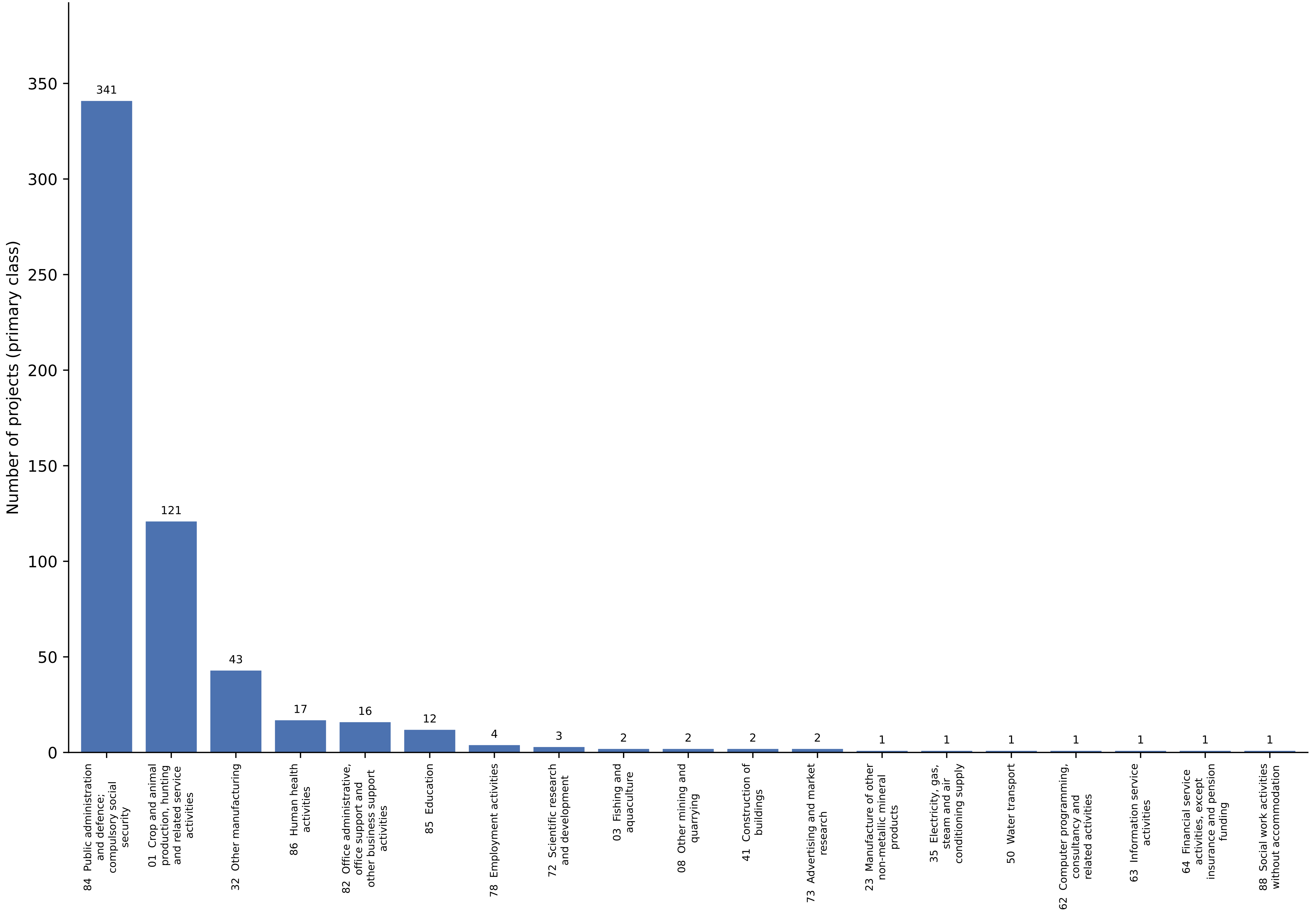

Table 2. Twenty most common primary classes — IHSN Catalogue (of 19 classes across 572 projects)

Rank	ISIC	ISIC Rev. 5 division	Count	Share
1	84	Public administration and defence; compulsory social security	341	59.6%
2	01	Crop and animal production, hunting and related service activities	121	21.2%
3	32	Other manufacturing	43	7.5%
4	86	Human health activities	17	3.0%
5	82	Office administrative, office support and other business support activities	16	2.8%
6	85	Education	12	2.1%
7	78	Employment activities	4	0.7%
8	72	Scientific research and development	3	0.5%
9	03	Fishing and aquaculture	2	0.3%
10	08	Other mining and quarrying	2	0.3%
11	41	Construction of buildings	2	0.3%
12	73	Advertising and market research	2	0.3%
13	23	Manufacture of other non-metallic mineral products	1	0.2%
14	35	Electricity, gas, steam and air conditioning supply	1	0.2%
15	50	Water transport	1	0.2%
16	62	Computer programming, consultancy and related activities	1	0.2%
17	63	Information service activities	1	0.2%
18	64	Financial service activities, except insurance and pension funding	1	0.2%
19	88	Social work activities without accommodation	1	0.2%

Comparison and closing remarks

The two collections could hardly differ more in shape. The Harvard/Murray Dataverse is broad and research-led, its projects scattered across 32 divisions with no single class exceeding 23% of the total. The IHSN Catalogue, by contrast, is narrow and administrative: 60% of its classified projects fall into one division.

For the purpose of seeding QDArchive this contrast is an asset rather than a problem. The academic dataverse supplies breadth across the health, social and natural sciences, while the statistical catalogue supplies depth in the survey and census material that underpins much applied research. Read together — and with the automated, division-level nature of the classification kept in mind — they offer a reasonable first map of the archive's early contents.